APPS

Google proposes to open Play Store to more real-money games in India

Jagmeet Singh — 1:57 PM PDT · July 30, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

Google has proposed sweeping changes to its Play Store and advertising policies in India, aiming to allow more real-money gaming apps onto its platforms in a bid to settle an ongoing antitrust case with a local online gaming platform WinZO.

On Wednesday, India's competition watchdog issued a public notice (PDF) inviting comments on a "commitment proposal" from Google, offering to expand access to its Play Store and advertising policy for more real-money gaming apps in the South Asian market.

Google proposed to replace its current pilot program by allowing the distribution of all real-money games in the country — which are "self-declared by developers as permissible online real-money games as per applicable laws/jurisprudence" — on Google Play.

However, the developers are also required to submit proof that an authoritative third-party body has declared the app to be a "game of skill," the company proposed.

In September 2022, Google launched a pilot program to allow daily fantasy sports and rummy games on its Play Store in India. The move came after a 2021 ruling by India's Supreme Court that categorized fantasy sports as "games of skill" rather than gambling — and therefore "legal."

Shortly after the pilot announced, online gaming platform WinZO filed a complaint with the Delhi High Court, calling the program discriminatory for excluding other real-money games. The Competition Commission of India (CCI) took up the case and, in November last year, ordered a formal probe into Google's policies for real-money gaming apps.

In January last year, Google announced it would expand support for real-money gaming apps on the Play Store in India, Brazil, and Mexico. However, the company paused that rollout in June 2024 and stated it would continue to allow apps already included in the 2022 India pilot to remain on the platform.

Alongside offering to expand its Play Store for all real-money games self-declared by developers, Google proposed to update its Developer Program Policies to reflect the update. The company also

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stated that it would finalize an “appropriate business model” for real-money game developers.

Similarly, Google has proposed to allow “games of skill” to be advertised in India where the app maker provides proof by a third party that it is a game of skill and not gambling.

The recognized third parties in this case could even be industry associations such as the All India Gaming Federation, E-Gaming Federation, or the Federation of Indian Fantasy Sports.

Google said it would begin allowing compliant real-money games on its Play Store in India within 120 days of the CCI’s approval, while related ad policy changes would take effect within 150 days of the regulator’s order.

“We’re pleased the CCI is market testing our proposed framework for real-money games (RMGs) in India,” a Google spokesperson said in a statement emailed to TechCrunch. “This development reflects our constructive discussions with the CCI and the Indian developer community along with our commitment to building a more open and safe ecosystem for RMG apps across Google Play and Google Ads.”

Notably, the proposal, if it is accepted by the CCI after public feedback, would benefit Google, which stands to earn a share of revenue from a broader range of real-money gaming apps and their ads on its platforms.

Real-money gaming dominates India’s online gaming market, accounting for nearly 86% of total industry revenue — ₹274.38 billion ($3 billion) in 2024 — per a joint report by WinZO and the Interactive Entertainment and Innovation Council (IEIC) released earlier this year. However, its share is expected to decline slightly to 80% by 2029, as non-real-money games grow in popularity and the overall market expands to ₹785.51 billion ($8.9 billion).

Google's latest proposal could also offer a boost to developers currently distributing their apps outside the Play Store — including via APK files on their own websites. However, the CCI's investigation is still ongoing, and the regulator has yet to determine whether Google engaged in discriminatory practices in this space.

The probe adds to a growing list of antitrust challenges for Google in India, where the U.S.-headquartered tech giant has already been fined for allegedly abusing its dominance through Android and the Play Store. The company recently approached the Supreme Court to appeal one of these rulings and contest the CCI's findings. The case is expected to be listed for hearing next month.

"We look forward to continuing to work with the CCI and the wider RMG ecosystem, and are confident our proposed framework will empower Indian developers, grow the digital economy, and prioritize user safety," Google's spokesperson said.

Jagmeet Singh

Reporter

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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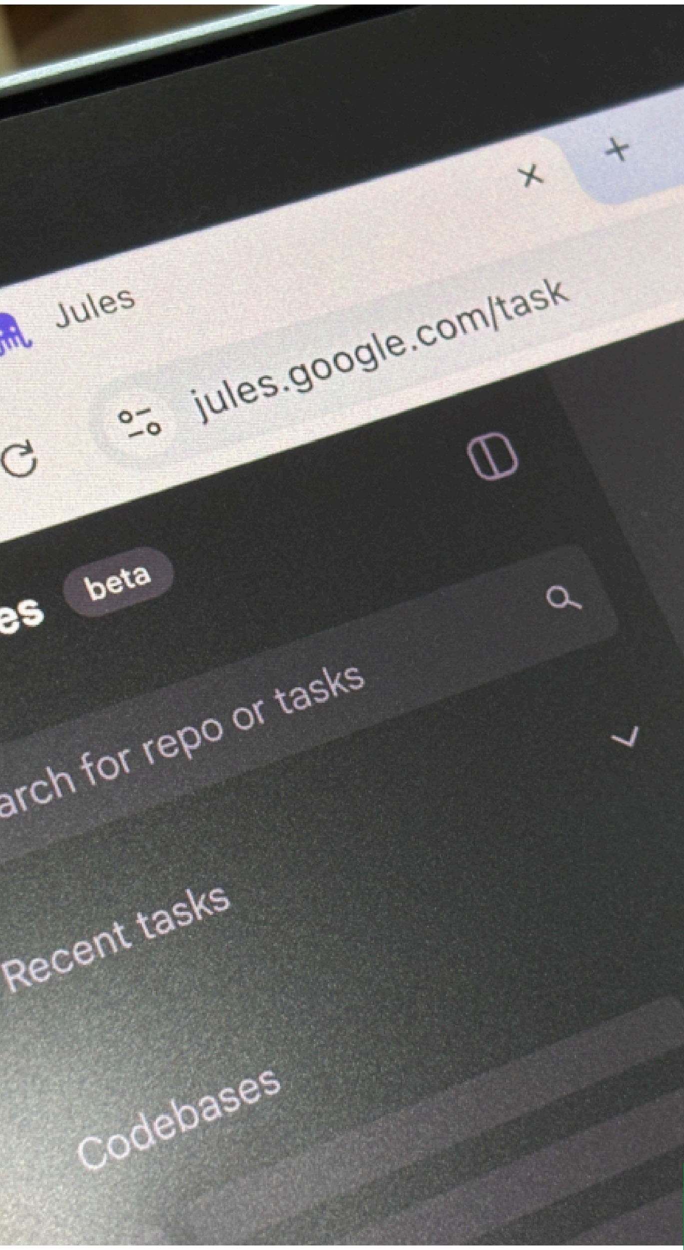

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

AI

Google's AI coding agent Jules is now out of beta

Jagmeet Singh — 9:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Google on Wednesday launched its AI coding agent, Jules, out of beta, just over two months after its public preview debut in May.

Powered by Gemini 2.5 Pro, Jules is an asynchronous, agent-based coding tool that integrates with GitHub, clones codebases into Google Cloud virtual machines, and uses AI to fix or update code while developers focus on other tasks.

Google initially announced Jules as a Google Labs project in December and made it available to beta testers through a public preview at its I/O developer conference.

Kathy Korevec, director of product at Google Labs, told TechCrunch that the tool's improved stability drove the decision to take it out of beta after receiving hundreds of UI and quality updates during its beta phase.

"The trajectory of where we're going gives us a lot of confidence that Jules is around and going to be around for the long haul," she said.

With the wider rollout, Google introduced structured pricing tiers for Jules, starting with an "introductory access" free plan capped at 15 individual daily tasks and three concurrent ones, down from the 60-task limit during beta. Jules' paid tiers are part of the Google AI Pro and Ultra plans, which are priced at $19.99 and $124.99 a month, and offer subscribers 5× and 20× higher limits, respectively.

Korevec noted that Jules' packaging and pricing are based on "real usage" insights gathered over the past couple of months.

"The 60-task cap helped us study how developers use Jules and gave us the information we needed to design the new packaging," she said. "The 15/day is designed to give people a sense of whether Jules will work for them on real project tasks."

Google also updated Jules' privacy policy to be more explicit about how it trains AI. If a repository is public, its data may be used for training, but if it is private, Korevec said that no data is sent.

"We got a little bit of feedback from users that it [the privacy policy] wasn't as clear as we thought it was, and so most of it is just responding to that. We didn't change anything about what we're doing on the training side, but we changed the language," Korevec said.

During the beta, Google said that thousands of developers tackled tens of thousands of tasks, resulting in over 140,000 code improvements shared publicly. Initial feedback led the Google Labs team to add new capabilities, including reusing previous setups for faster task execution, integrating with GitHub issues, and supporting multimodal input.

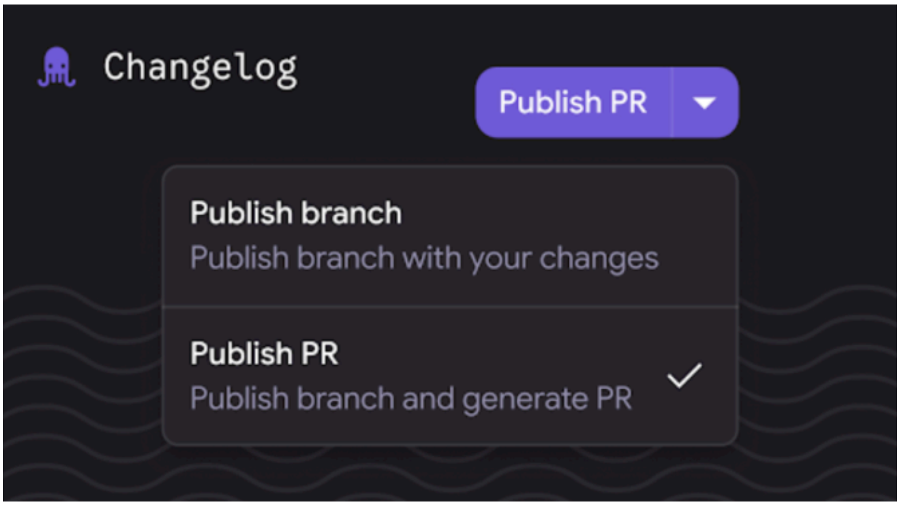

IMAGE CREDITS:JULES / X

The two primary users of Jules so far are the AI enthusiasts and professional developers, Korevec said.

By running asynchronously in a virtual machine, Jules stands apart from top AI coding tools like Cursor, Windsurf, and Lovable, which all work synchronously and require users to watch the output after each prompt.

"Jules operates like an extra set of hands … you can basically kick off tasks to it, and then you could close your computer and walk away from it if you want and then come back hours later. Jules would have those tasks done for you, versus if you were doing that with a local agent or using a synchronous agent, you would be bound to that session," Korevec explained.

This week, Jules received a deeper integration with GitHub to open pull requests automatically — just like it could open branches — and a feature called Environment Snapshots to save dependencies and install scripts as a snapshot for faster, more consistent task execution.

From vibe coding to mobile use, beta trials informed Jules' development

Since entering public beta, Jules has logged 2.28 million visits worldwide, 45% of them from mobile devices, per data from market intelligence provider SimilarWeb, reviewed by TechCrunch. India was the top market for traffic, followed by the U.S. and Vietnam.

Google did not share specifics on Jules' user base and its top geographies.

Korevec told TechCrunch that during the beta, the team observed that many people used Jules from traditional vibe-coding tools to either fix bugs that might have been implemented or extend the vibe-coded project to make it more production-ready.

Originally, Jules required users to have an existing codebase. But Google soon realized many potential users — like those trying other AI tools — might want to explore it without one. Korevec said the company quickly enabled Jules to work even with an empty repository. That helped increase its scope and usage.

Google Labs' team also noticed an increasing number of users accessing Jules through their mobile devices. Although the tool does not have a dedicated mobile app, Korevec said users were accessing it through its web app.

"Since it's a big use case that we're seeing emerging, we're absolutely exploring what the features are that people need on mobile a lot more," she noted.

Alongside beta testers, Korevec stated that Google already uses Jules to help develop some projects internally, and there is now a "big push" to use the tool on "a lot more projects" at the company.

Topics: AI Google Google Jules jules United States

Jagmeet Singh
Reporter

Payment platform Lava raises $5.8M to build digital wallets for the ‘agent-native economy’

Dominic-Madori Davis — 8:45 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: JJ JUMOC-CASAS

A new startup, Lava Payments, aims to take on payment giants by building a solution for the modern web where AI agents now handle transactions for their customers. The idea came to founder Mitchell Jones after he left his earlier Y Combinator-backed fintech startup, Lendtable, as he began to experiment with AI.

He saw the potential to build out a system that would make using AI and agent payments simpler and more developer-friendly. While experimenting with an AI app and trying to build what he thought was something simple, he realized he quickly spent more than $400 trying to build a basic form-filling agent.

“I kept running into the same issue,” he told TechCrunch. “I was using the same underlying

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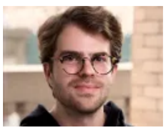

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models and tools again and again, but through different wrappers or platforms." And each time, he had to start a new subscription, re-authenticate, and pay separately, "even though I was already paying for access to the core model."

"That felt fundamentally broken," he continued. "I didn't want to keep rebuying access to the same thing under a different wrapper. What I wanted was a single wallet, one set of credits, and the ability to move between tools and providers without starting over every time so I could pay for what I was using."

He decided to launch Lava Payments as a solution.

Lava is a digital wallet that lets merchants use usage credits to facilitate transactions.

The idea is that one set of credits working across merchants and services makes it easier for autonomous agents to make payments without needing human intervention. It works like this: A merchant can enable the Lava wallet for their customers to use and upload (credits) money to. Once a customer does that, they can take that money and use it at any merchant that also accepts Lava and any of the foundational models, like GPT and Claude, on a "pay as you go basis," Jones said.

So, rather than having to pay for each tool, a user buys a one-time usage credit that AI agents can simply charge as they perform various tasks. No more asking the user to approve transaction after transaction.

"Without Lava, agents can't move smoothly through the internet because they constantly get blocked when it comes time to pay," he said. He used Google as an example, saying every time a person opens Google Maps, they don't have to pay Google for that map, as they've already paid Verizon and AT&T to access the internet.

On Wednesday, the startup announced a $5.8 million seed round led by Lerer Hippeau.

Others in this space include startups like Metronome.

“We see the world as very interconnected,” Jones said about what makes his product different. “What we’re really focused on is building [for the] agent-native economy.”

Born to a working family in Dayton, Ohio, Jones said his parents always told him the best way to get ahead was to work hard, save money, and get a good education.

“You know, a lot of the things that most people are told,” he recalled, when speaking with TechCrunch.

Jones took that advice to heart. He got a good education (Yale), held some good jobs (Goldman, Meta), and then founded some companies (the fintechs Parable and Lendtable, the latter of which was YC S20).

Jones said he met his lead investors for Lava because he went to high school with Will McKelvey, now an investor at Lerer Hippeau. He said McKelvey has been following his career for a while and always wanted to work together someday, and Lava Payments was that someday.

Others in the round included Harlem Capital, Streamlined Ventures, and Westbound. The fresh capital will be used for hiring, building products, and developing go-to-market strategies.

Overall, Jones is ready for Lava to be the “invisible layer that kind of powers the AI web,” he says, especially as AI agents find themselves more and more in the checkout line.

“We should be enabling agents to move, transact, and build without friction,” he said.

“We want to make sure that AI is something that can be used by every single person, even a kid from Dayton, like myself.”

The title of this piece was updated to properly reflect what the company does.

Topics: AI Fintech Lerer Hippeau payments Startups

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Qwant and Ecosia debut Staan, a European

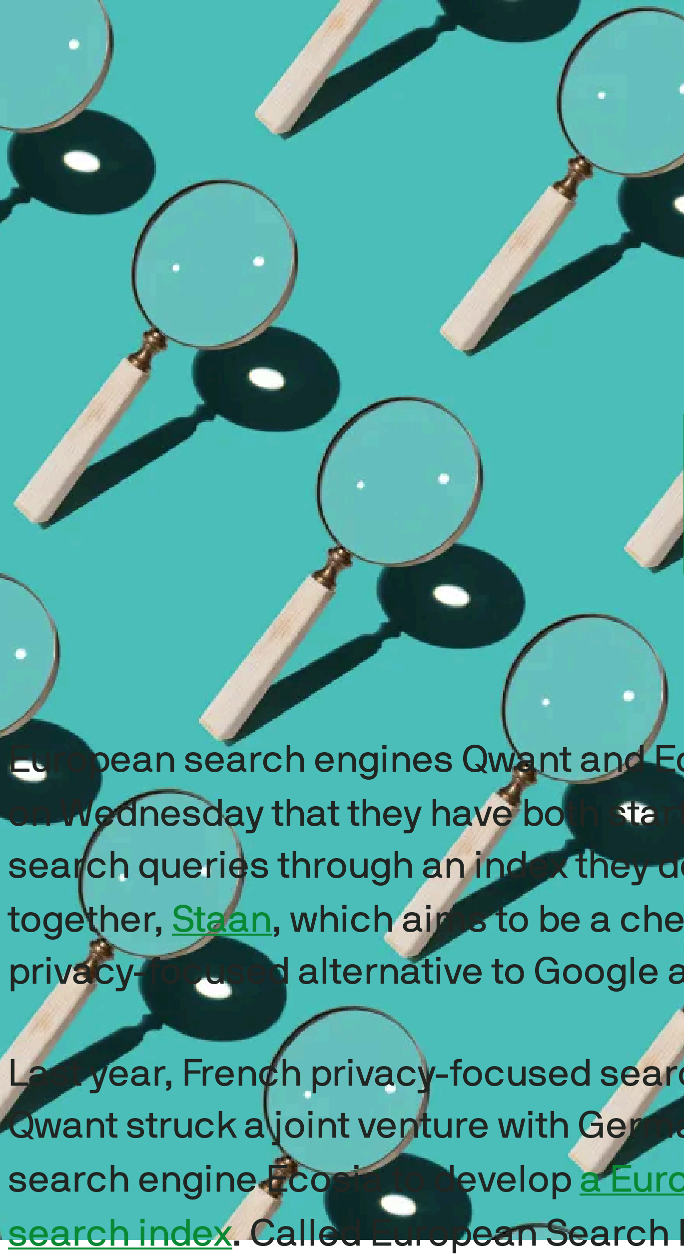

IMAGE CREDITS: MIRAGEC / GETTY IMAGES

search index that aims to take on Big Tech

Ivan Mehta — 4:45 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

European search engines Qwant and Ecosia said on Wednesday that they have both started serving search queries through an index they developed together, Staan, which aims to be a cheaper, more privacy-focused alternative to Google and Bing.

Last year, French privacy-focused search engine Qwant struck a joint venture with German non-profit search engine Ecosia to develop a European search index. Called European Search Perspective (EUSP), the JV now aims to serve around 50% of French queries and 33% of German queries by the end of the year.

Qwant said it is using the new index to power some of its features, like AI summaries for search, and Ecosia has plans to add some AI features soon to its platform, too.

EUSP is also in talks with companies to spur the adoption of its index for enabling search within apps. Notably, it is targeting chatbots, presenting Staan as a cheaper alternative to Google and Bing.

“If you’re using ChatGPT or any other AI chatbot, they all do knowledge grounding with web search … our index can power deep research and AI summary features. Google and Bing’s solutions are also pricey, and our index can offer power search features at a tenth of the cost," Christian Kroll, CEO of Ecosia, told TechCrunch.

EUSP, like Proton, is pushing to develop a European tech stack that doesn't rely on technology from the U.S. or China.

"The timing could not be more urgent. The outcome of the 2024 U.S. election has reminded European policymakers and innovators just how exposed Europe remains when it comes to core digital infrastructure. Much of Europe's search, cloud, and AI layers are built on American Big Tech stacks, putting entire sectors — from journalism to climate tech — at the mercy of political or commercial agendas," the companies said in a statement.

Kroll added that through this index, combined with European privacy laws, EUSP can offer a more privacy-friendly search solution as compared to its U.S. counterparts.

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